from the start. Moreover during the mid-twentieth century, Cuba's place as a site for tourism, pleasure, and sin was highly sexualized. It was no wonder, as Ian Lekus has argued, that "the revolutionary government made eradicating this [sexualized] colonial economy a priority … Given the especially sexualized nature of Cuba's past relationship with the United States … sexual reform became all the more important to symbolizing the revolution's rejection of Yanqui domination."[29]

This sexual reform did not incorporate ideas about gay rights, however. The gay rights movement of the 1960s and 70s was challenging norms of prejudice and exclusion in the United States, and in fact offering new ways of defining gay identity, just as the close connection between Cuba and the United States was broken. Meanwhile, new elements shaped by Communist ideology and by Soviet sexology as well as Cuba's own form of revolutionary machismo contributed to both official and unofficial repression against sexual non-conformity during the first decades of the Cuban Revolution.

Repression of homosexuality reached its highest point during the first decade of the Revolution. The battlefield mentality of the Revolution was exacerbated by the unremitting threats from the United States, and the overwhelming challenge of recreating the economy. In 1963, the government instituted a military draft for men aged between 16 and 45. The draft also became a means of separating out those who the authorities considered potentially subversive or otherwise unfit for military service. By 1965, those thus identified were being sent to newly established "Military Units to Aid Production" or UMAPs – something between a concentration camp, a prison labor facility, and a rehabilitation program.

Men who were openly homosexual fit squarely into that category. "Nothing prevents a homosexual from professing revolutionary ideology and, consequently, exhibiting a correct political position," Fidel Castro told Lee Lockwood in 1965. "And yet," he went on, "we would never come to believe that a homosexual could embody the conditions and requirements of conduct that would enable us to consider him a true Revolutionary, a true Communist militant. A deviation of that nature